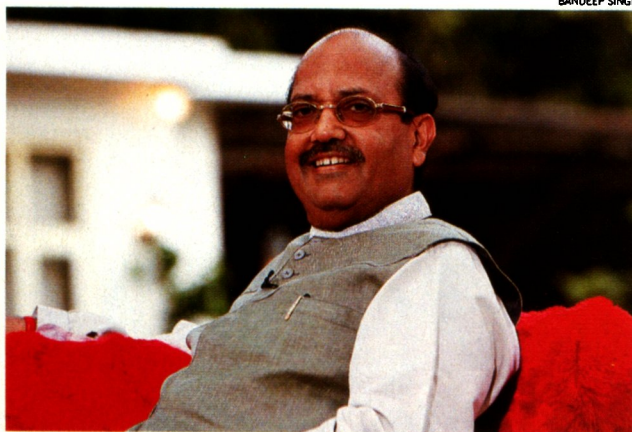


BANDEEP SINGH



Friend in Deed

DELHI Q. What did the Congress gain out of the Indo-US nuclear deal?
A. Amar Singh.

The Samajwadi Party leader's hand of friendship to the Congress is extending well beyond the trust vote. At a time when an old ally Lalu Yadav launched a veiled attack on Home Minister Shivraj Patil, it was Amar Singh who

rushed in where even Congressmen feared to tread. "Advani didn't resign when Parliament was attacked, why are you singling out Patil? Changing clothes is not a crime," he chided the media.

The defence is not surprising as Singh's party regards SIMI as a cultural outfit. However, Singh added that he was hurt by

STAUNCH ALLY: Singh

the Congress which engineered the defection of four Samajwadi Party MLAs in Madhya Pradesh. "The Congress not only broke my party, but also my heart," Singh declared theatrically. "The SP will not ally with the Congress in Madhya Pradesh but the alliance in Uttar Pradesh stands. I'm a Kshatriya and will abide by my commitment even if they don't."

The Congress wants 22 seats in Uttar Pradesh but the SP wants to give it only 15. Of these, 12 have been decided including nine sitting Congress MPs and three others. One of these is Noida from where BJP chief Rajnath Singh may contest. This leaves little scope for negotiation. But like him or not, the Congress now has a staunch ally in Singh.

by Priya Sehgal

Giving to Take

LUCKNOW It's a classic case of giving by one hand and taking with the other. After a long struggle by All India Haj Sewa Samiti, an apolitical outfit fighting for the welfare of Hajis, the Centre has increased the quota of Muslims going on pilgrimage to Mecca. The number has been hiked by 13,000, but the Centre has kept applications under its control to oblige its favourites. An estimated 1.60 lakh applicants were left out this time.

The Central Government already has a quota



YASBANT NEGI

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

Swirling Change

LUCKNOW The infamous Chambal Valley, the erstwhile paradise for dacoits, is gearing up for a makeover. Its barren landscape with deep gorges and ravines will soon see wind energy plants and its earth will be used for biofuel.

With most of the major dacoit gangs—Malkhan Singh in the early '50s, slain bandit queen Phoolan Devi in the '80s and the Dadua, Nirbhay and Thokia gangs—eliminated, a plantation drive is underway in the Chambals and people are being encouraged to culti-



CULTIVATED VALLEY: The Chambals will get a makeover

vate medicinal plants. The governments of Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh want to utilise the vast land in the Valley. The Madhya Pradesh Government has already signed agreements with agri-business-

based companies to plant saplings. If a new dacoit gang does not spoil their dreams, the day is not far when people can move around in the Chambals freely and earn a livelihood by producing biofuel. by Subhash Mishra

UNHAPPY: Hajis

of 6,000, which it gives to those who are politically connected. This has angered Ulemas, Hajis and the Samiti. The Government also eats into the Haj subsidy of Rs 4,500 crore to make up for the losses incurred by Air India, the nodal carriers. During the last Haj session, Air India was accused of harassing and humiliating the pilgrims. This was why the Samiti and the Ulemas had demanded selecting a carrier through a global tender. The Samiti has now declared that unless the increased quota was handed over to Haj committees, they would rake up the "humiliation" of Hajis as an election issue.

by Farzand Ahmad